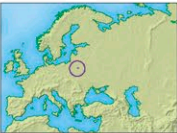


Bison bonasus

European bison



Length 7–11 ft (2.1–3.4 m)
Tail 12–23½ in (30–60 cm)
Weight 770–2,200 lb (350–1,000 kg)
Location E. Europe
Social unit Group
Status Vulnerable



Formerly extinct in the wild, the European bison has been park bred and reintroduced into the coniferous

Bialoweiza Forest (which straddles the Polish and Belarussian border), where original populations survived until the 1910s. It has a slightly lighter and shorter coat than the American bison, but its habits and herding behavior are similar. The horns, larger in the male, are short and upturned. This bison browses on leaves, twigs, and bark, and grazes on low vegetation. Typical group sizes range from 8 to 13, but in more open habitats there may be 20 or more. The single calf is born after a gestation period of 254–279 days. It can run within 3 hours and is weaned by one year.



Bos gaurus

Gaur



Length 8¼–11 ft (2.5–3.3 m)
Tail 28–39 in (70–100 cm)
Weight 1,430–2,210 lb (650–1,000 kg)
Location S. to S.E. Asia
Social unit Group
Status Vulnerable



Among the biggest cattle, the gaur (seladang or Indian bison) has a huge head and deep body in shades of red, brown, and black, and sturdy, whitish limbs. The horns are up to 3½ ft (1.1 m) long. Rutting males “sing” with bellows that deepen in pitch and carry for 1 mile (1.5 km). There is a muscular ridge, supported by bony extensions of the vertebrae, running over the shoulder to the middle of the back. The social system and mixed herbage diet are typical of other wild cattle.



Philatomba walteri

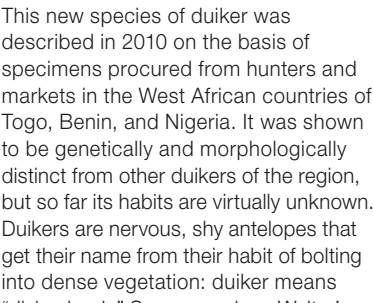
Walter’s duiker



Length 21½–29½ in (55–75 cm)
Tail Up to 5¼ in (15 cm)
Weight 13–26 lb (6–12 kg)
Location W. Africa
Social unit Group
Status Data deficient



This new species of duiker was described in 2010 on the basis of specimens procured from hunters and markets in the West African countries of Togo, Benin, and Nigeria. It was shown to be genetically and morphologically distinct from other duikers of the region, but so far its habits are virtually unknown. Duikers are nervous, shy antelopes that get their name from their habit of bolting into dense vegetation: duiker means “diving buck.” Some—such as Walter’s duiker—prefer rain forest to open woodland. Unusually for ungulates, duikers supplement their diet with animal matter—such as insects—and have even been known to kill birds in captivity. The discovery of Walter’s duiker highlights the importance of conservation in a part of Africa where exploitation of bushmeat threatens local wildlife. The species is additionally threatened by habitat clearance associated with human population growth.



Sylvicapra grimmia

Common duiker



Length 2¼–3¼ ft (0.7–1.1 m)
Tail 4–7¾ in (10–20 cm)
Weight 22–58 lb (10–26 kg)
Location W., C., E., and southern Africa
Social unit Individual/Pair
Status Least concern



The common duiker has a tufted forehead, large, pointed ears, and, usually only in males, sharp-pointed horns about 4¼ in (11 cm) long. It is gray to red-yellow haired above, with white underparts, and has a dark nose stripe. Adaptable in habitat, it is a nocturnal browser and also takes small animals and carrion. It lives alone or in pairs, and males defend their territories against rivals.

Kobus defassa

Defassa waterbuck



Length 5½–7½ ft (1.7–2.3 m)
Tail 13–15¼ in (33–40 cm)
Weight 350–580 lb (160–260 kg)
Location W., C., and E. Africa
Social unit Individual/Group
Status Near threatened



One of the heaviest antelopes, the defassa waterbuck has coarse, long, oily hair that ranges in color from gray to red-brown and darkens with age. There are white markings on the rump, throat, and muzzle, and white “eyebrows,” rings above the hooves, and underparts. The horns, normally present only in the male, are up to 3¼ ft (1 m) long. Some 50 percent of the diet is grass, the rest browsed leaves. When threatened, the animal usually dashes to water, where it swims fast or submerges except for the nose. Herds of younger males, usually 2–5 but rarely 50 or more, have a hierarchy based on visual displays, horn length, and frequent fights. Older (6–10 years) breeding males occupy territories. Females live in small maternal groups (usually 3–6, max 25) that vary frequently. There are no strong individual bonds.

Kobus leche

Kafue flats lechwe



Length 5¼ ft (1.6 m)
Tail 13¾ in (35 cm)
Weight 135–280 lb (62–128 kg)
Location Zambia
Social unit Group
Status Vulnerable



The Kafue flats lechwe, or marsh antelope, eats grasses and aquatic plants exposed by seasonal variations in the weather, responding to water levels across floodplains and swamps. It wades and swims well, forms large herds, and has the lek breeding system (see Ugandan kob, right). The chestnut to black coat contrasts with the white underparts and black leg stripes. Only the males are horned.

